When Marriage Becomes Captivity

A practical and scriptural guide for pastors, elders, and lay helpers on recognizing and responding to coercive control

Who this document is for

Pastors, elders, small group leaders, deacons, counselors, church staff, and lay helpers who are in a position to receive a disclosure of abuse — or to miss one. It is written for non-denominational evangelical, Vineyard, Reformed, Baptist, and similar Protestant traditions, though most of the material applies across Christian denominations.

It assumes the reader takes scripture seriously, cares about marriage, and wants to help. It is written with the conviction that those commitments are best served by understanding what coercive control actually is, what scripture actually says about it, and what the mainstream of the Christian church actually teaches on the question of whether abuse is grounds for separation and divorce.

This document has seven parts:

- **Part 1:** The landscape of abuse beyond physical violence
- **Part 2:** Neurodivergent victims and why standard signs may be absent
- **Part 3:** Immigrant and multigenerational-family dynamics
- **Part 4:** What scripture actually says about abuse and marriage
- **Part 5:** Common pastoral mistakes, and what to do instead
- **Part 6:** Practical protocols when a disclosure happens
- **Part 7:** Resources, training, and further reading

A printable quick-reference card is included at the end.

PART 1

The landscape of abuse beyond physical violence

Most pastors are clued into physical violence. The pastoral blind spots are elsewhere. What follows is a map of the common forms of non-physical abuse — not to turn pastors into diagnosticians, but to equip them to recognize when a "marriage problem" is actually something that needs professional referral.

The categories below overlap. A single relationship often contains several patterns at once. The point is not to pick one label — it is to notice when **any** of these patterns is present, because the pastoral response that helps a genuinely difficult marriage will actively harm any of them.

Patterns of non-physical abuse

- **Coercive control.** A sustained pattern in which one partner dominates the other through isolation, surveillance, monitoring, financial control, rules, and threats. May or may not include physical violence — many severe cases do not. The defining feature is the *pattern of dominance,* not any single tactic. This is the most commonly missed pattern in pastoral settings, so most of this document focuses on it.
- **Emotional abuse.** Contempt, humiliation, name-calling, put-downs, the silent treatment, explosive anger used as intimidation. Can occur within coercive control, or (less often) on its own without a full control pattern.
- **Spiritual abuse.** Scripture, theology, church authority, or claimed spiritual gifts used as weapons. Examples: claiming a spouse is spiritually unwell, demonically influenced, or under attack in ways only the abuser can discern; using prayer, deliverance, or spiritual practices against the spouse's will or consent; invoking "headship" or "submission" to override the spouse's conscience; recruiting pastors or elders to pressure compliance; claiming special revelation or prophetic authority about what the spouse needs. Spiritual abuse often coexists with other patterns but deserves its own recognition because pastors are uniquely positioned to see it — and uniquely likely to accidentally participate in it.
- **Gaslighting.** Systematically making the victim doubt their own perceptions, memory, or sanity. "That didn't happen." "You're remembering it wrong." "You're too sensitive." "You're imagining things." Often paired with small manufactured events designed to destabilize the victim's reality-testing.
- **DARVO.** An acronym for Deny, Attack, Reverse Victim and Offender. When confronted, the abuser denies the behavior, attacks the person raising it, and reframes themselves as the real victim. Watch for this pattern when the abuser or their family describes the victim as ungrateful, impossible to please, hysterical, the real aggressor, or mentally unwell. DARVO is a *tactic* that appears inside other patterns.
- **Narcissistic abuse cycles.** Idealize, devalue, discard, and hoover (pull back in). The relationship runs on extreme highs followed by devaluation, with periodic return of the charming early version just often enough to keep the victim hoping. This is not a formal diagnosis of the abuser — it is a description of the relational pattern the victim is living inside.
- **Trauma bonding / intermittent reinforcement.** The victim becomes powerfully attached to the abuser through cycles of cruelty followed by warmth. This is the neurochemistry of unpredictable reward — the same mechanism that makes slot machines addictive. **Pastors need to understand this** because it explains why victims return, defend their abuser, minimize, and leave and return multiple times. It is not weakness, confusion, or lack of faith. It is a measurable physiological response.
- **Financial abuse.** Control of money, employment sabotage, hidden assets, running up debt in the victim's name, requiring accounting for every dollar, withholding funds for basic needs. A major reason victims cannot leave.
- **Reactive abuse framing.** After sustained abuse, the victim eventually lashes out — yelling, crying, breaking something, sending an angry text. The abuser records or reports this moment as proof that the

victim is "the real abuser." Family members, lawyers, and (unfortunately) pastors can be recruited into this framing. Watch for a "victim" whose only evidence of the other's abuse is a single dramatic outburst during a clearly escalating conflict.

- **Post-separation abuse.** Abuse that intensifies *after* the victim leaves — often the phase pastors are most likely to encounter. Tactics include legal abuse (frivolous motions, custody threats), using children as weapons or messengers, paper abuse (endless filings), stalking, smear campaigns to mutual contacts and the church, and recruiting clergy into the abuser's narrative. Many divorcing abuse victims lose custody or suffer worse outcomes post-separation than during the marriage — because the abuse pattern adapts to use the court and community as tools. If a pastor is hearing from a divorcing husband that his wife is crazy / unreasonable / keeping the kids from him, that pastor may be encountering post-separation abuse, not a difficult divorce.

The pastoral epiphany

Physical violence is one form of abuse among many. The patterns above can destroy a person — their identity, their faith, their capacity to function, their relationships with their children — without ever leaving a bruise. Many victims say later that the non-physical abuse was worse.

A pastor does not need to diagnose which specific pattern is present. The pastoral task is to **notice the patterns exist,** stop treating the situation as a garden-variety marriage problem, and refer to professionals who can sort it out. The rest of this document helps with that noticing.

Coercive control: the most commonly-missed pattern

Of the patterns above, coercive control is the one most likely to be presented to a pastor as "a communication problem" or "a difficult marriage." It is also the one where the standard pastoral repertoire does the most damage. The rest of Part 1 focuses on recognizing it specifically.

Coercive control is a sustained pattern of behavior by one partner intended to dominate and dictate the life of the other. It is not merely anger, occasional harsh words, or poor conflict resolution. It is a strategy — often semi-conscious but sometimes entirely deliberate — of obtaining and maintaining control over another person's thoughts, decisions, relationships, resources, and sense of self.

The core distinction pastors need to hold:

- **A difficult marriage** involves two partners who both contribute to the pattern, both have agency, both can speak freely, and both want the marriage to improve.
- **A destructive (coercive-control) marriage** involves one partner systematically constraining the other. One partner has agency; the other is adapting to survive. One partner can speak freely; the other cannot without consequences.

Leslie Vernick, a Christian licensed counselor, formalized this distinction in *The Emotionally Destructive Marriage* (2013), and it has become standard language in the field. The pastoral implications are significant: the strategies that help a difficult marriage actively worsen a destructive one.

Warning signs in pastoral counseling sessions

In a joint session

- One partner speaks for both, corrects the other's account, or interrupts repeatedly
- The other partner checks their spouse's face before answering questions
- One is articulate, charming, and composed; the other seems shut down, flat, over-apologetic, or confused
- The charismatic partner frames everything as "we both need to work on this," while the other accepts disproportionate blame
- Stories don't match observable evidence — the "calmer" partner's account contradicts what you've seen or heard elsewhere
- One partner pathologizes the other: "She's mentally ill," "He's on the spectrum, he can't read people," "She's hormonal," "He's just anxious."
- The pathologizing partner presents as the long-suffering, reasonable one managing a difficult spouse. This framing is itself a warning sign, not evidence.

Ask about in individual session (never joint)

- **Money:** Does one partner control all finances, give the other an allowance, or require accounting of spending? Does one partner's name appear on accounts the other has no access to?
- **Isolation:** Has one partner progressively lost contact with friends, family, or church community? Does visiting family require permission?
- **Surveillance:** Does one monitor the other's phone, email, social media, or location? Have passwords been demanded?
- **Criticism disguised as care:** Is criticism framed as "helping" or "spiritual leadership" or "protection"?
- **Threats for compliance:** Threats of divorce, custody loss, financial ruin, suicide, outing (for LGBTQ+ victims), deportation (for immigrant victims), or exposure — used to gain compliance.
- **Children as leverage:** Are the children used as informants, as threats, or as emotional hostages?

- **The eggshells test:** Does one partner manage their own behavior carefully to avoid the other's anger? Can you detect which one?

Red flags that this is not a communication problem

- One partner is afraid of the other — even if they cannot name it as fear, or call it something else
- Progressive loss of activities, friendships, autonomy, or identity
- Any history of physical violence, sexual coercion, or property destruction
- Gaslighting patterns — being told they are "crazy," "too sensitive," "imagining things"
- Problems always framed as the victim's fault, including by the victim themselves
- One partner's diagnosis, neurotype, mental health history, or cultural background is used as a weapon against them
- A family or community pattern of pressuring one spouse to submit, accept, or forgive

The single most useful diagnostic question

"Are you ever afraid of your spouse?" Ask it individually, in a private setting, with no possibility the spouse could hear or find out. A long pause is an answer. Reframing the question ("well, not afraid, but...") is an answer. The word "no" is only reliable when it comes immediately and with confusion at the question.

PART 2

Neurodivergent victims

Standard warning signs assume neurotypical communication and emotional expression. For autistic, ADHD, and other neurodivergent adults — especially women, who are frequently diagnosed late or not at all — abuse often looks different, and can be missed or misattributed.

The research is blunt. Autistic women report stalking and harassment at 61% versus 24% in non-autistic women; sexual violence at 60% versus 33%; physical violence at 50% versus 29%. A 2024 meta-analysis found 84% of autistic adults reported victimization in more than one category (Douglas & Sedgewick, *Autism*, 2024). Among women with ADHD, 56.3% are at elevated risk of intimate partner victimization. Autistic women are roughly nine times more likely than neurotypical women to report having experienced sexual violence (Cazalis et al., *Frontiers in Behavioral Neuroscience*, 2022).

Why neurodivergent people are at elevated risk

- **Lifelong masking and compliance.** Many neurodivergent women spend their lives suppressing their natural responses and mirroring acceptable behavior to avoid rejection. The same skill that helped them survive school and workplace — compliance to avoid negative attention — is exactly what an abuser exploits. By the time they are in an abusive marriage, compliance is automatic.
- **Literal interpretation.** Autistic people often take words at face value. "I'm sorry, it won't happen again" is believed completely the first time, the tenth time, the hundredth time. Sarcasm, implied threats, and manipulative undertones may be missed entirely.
- **Rejection sensitive dysphoria (common in ADHD).** RSD creates extraordinary emotional pain from perceived rejection. An abuser can weaponize this — the threat of abandonment or disapproval becomes an overwhelming control tool. The victim may tolerate escalating abuse rather than face the unbearable pain of rupture.
- **Executive function challenges.** Adults with ADHD often have genuine difficulty with scheduling, finances, and task-switching. They may hand over these tasks to a partner because doing so is practically necessary. An abuser exploits this to create dependence, then frames the dependence as evidence that the victim "can't manage alone."
- **Pre-existing isolation.** Many neurodivergent adults have fewer close friendships due to lifelong social differences. They may lack the comparison point of healthy relationships and have no one to reality-test their experience against. The abuser did not need to isolate them; they were already isolated.
- **A lifetime of being told they are "wrong."** Neurodivergent people often grow up being told they are too much, not enough, too sensitive, too loud, too quiet. When an abuser says the same things, it does not feel like abuse. It feels like confirmation of what they have always been told.

Why gaslighting hits harder

Gaslighting is devastating for anyone, but it is uniquely effective against neurodivergent people for three reasons:

- **Self-gaslighting is already a survival habit.** Many neurodivergent people routinely invalidate their own perceptions as a survival strategy — "Maybe I'm being too sensitive; maybe I'm misreading this." An abuser's gaslighting layers on top of an existing practice and is indistinguishable from it.
- **Memory and processing differences.** ADHD involves genuine differences in memory encoding and retrieval. An abuser who says "that's not what happened" is exploiting a real vulnerability. Autistic memory is often extremely accurate for detail but less reliable for narrative sequencing, which the abuser can exploit in the other direction.

- **Social-cue uncertainty.** Difficulty reading social cues means the victim may not realize their discomfort is justified. They may assume their reaction is another case of "misunderstanding" social norms — rather than an accurate response to abuse.

What pastors should watch for beyond standard signs

- **The "interpreter" dynamic.** The partner frames themselves as the spokesperson or caretaker: "She can't really manage finances / schedule / the kids on her own." "I have to handle things because of her condition." The partner positions themselves as heroically shouldering the burden of a difficult spouse.
- **Weaponized diagnosis.** The partner uses autism or ADHD as the explanation for the victim's distress rather than acknowledging their own behavior. "She's just having a meltdown." "That's her ADHD talking." "She can't regulate her emotions." Pathologizing a partner's neurotype as the cause of marriage problems is itself a documented coercive tactic.
- **Escalating "symptoms."** Increased meltdowns, shutdowns, stimming, sleep problems, or executive function collapse may indicate rising abuse, not worsening autism or ADHD. A previously high-functioning adult who now "can't" do things they used to do may be experiencing the cumulative cost of having every decision overridden or criticized.
- **Loss of coping strategies.** Special interests suppressed, sensory needs dismissed, routines disrupted, stim objects taken away, regulation time denied. Controlling a neurodivergent person's access to their regulation strategies is abuse specific to this population.
- **Self-blame framed through diagnosis.** "If I weren't autistic, things would be fine." "I'm too much for him." "I know I'm hard to live with because of my ADHD." The victim has internalized the abuser's framing that their neurotype is the problem.
- **Flat or incongruent affect when describing frightening events.** An autistic victim may recount severe incidents calmly or with unusual detail. This is not proof they are fine. It is often proof they have learned to dissociate from their own distress.
- **Fawning and over-accommodation.** Agreeing, apologizing, and placating far past what circumstances warrant. This is the "fawn" response in the fight/flight/freeze/fawn model, and it is especially common among late-diagnosed autistic women.

What NOT to do

- **Do not assume the neurodivergent partner is the difficult one.** Abusers frequently present as the patient, long-suffering partner managing someone challenging. This narrative is a red flag, not evidence of reality.
- **Do not attribute abuse symptoms to the diagnosis.** Anxiety, depression, shutdown, meltdowns, and executive-function collapse are all symptoms of living under coercive control. They do not require a neurological explanation when the relational one fits.
- **Do not recommend the victim "work on their communication."** In an abusive dynamic, clearer communication gives the abuser more information to use. Teaching a neurodivergent victim to "express her needs better" often results in the abuser learning exactly what to target.
- **Do not involve the partner in discussions about the victim's neurodivergence.** Clinical language, diagnostic information, and coping strategies disclosed in a joint session will be weaponized later.
- **Do not assume autism or ADHD makes someone an unreliable narrator.** Neurodivergent people are often more accurate than neurotypical people about factual details and patterns, even when they are less confident in their own account.

PART 3

Immigrant and multigenerational-family dynamics

Standard pastoral training on domestic abuse largely assumes an Anglo-American nuclear family model — two spouses, possibly children, possibly a couple of involved parents, but with the marriage as the primary relational unit. In many immigrant and traditionally collectivist families, this is not the structure. The marriage is embedded in an extended-family system, and the extended family is often a central site of the abuse, not peripheral to it.

Coercive control in multigenerational-family contexts often involves not just the spouse but the spouse's parents, siblings, grandparents, and wider network. Pastoral responses designed for two-person dynamics miss this entirely. The research on Latino, South Asian, Middle Eastern, and East Asian immigrant communities is converging on a common pattern: abuse is frequently a **family project,** not a single-perpetrator act.

This does not mean cultural backgrounds cause abuse. Abuse occurs in every culture, every community, every faith tradition. What varies is the specific mechanisms through which it is enforced, the specific scriptures and traditions that may be weaponized to justify it, and the specific barriers that prevent victims from leaving.

Cultural values that can be weaponized (but are not themselves abuse)

Several cultural values common in immigrant and traditional communities are healthy in their ordinary expression but can be exploited by abusers and their allies. Understanding the values helps pastors recognize when they are being misused.

Familismo (Latino / Hispanic cultures)

The cultural value of deep family loyalty, interdependence, and prioritization of family unity. In healthy expression, *familismo* provides social support, collective care for children and elders, and shared identity. In abusive contexts, it becomes the framework through which a wife is pressured to remain in a marriage "for the family," to not "bring shame" on the family by disclosing, or to accept interference from in-laws as normal and expected. A woman who sets boundaries with her husband's family may be framed as rejecting the entire culture, not just asserting a reasonable limit.

Marianismo (Latino / Hispanic cultures, Catholic-influenced)

The cultural expectation that women embody Marian virtues — self-sacrifice, spiritual superiority, long-suffering patience, and silence-for-harmony. Castillo et al.'s Marianismo Beliefs Scale identifies five pillars: Family Pillar, Virtuous and Chaste, Subordinate to Others, Silencing Self to Maintain Harmony, and Spiritual Pillar. The research (Nuñez et al., *Violence Against Women*, 2015) shows direct correlation between marianismo endorsement and increased psychological distress among Latina women experiencing IPV. The "good wife" does not leave; she suffers for her family. Abusive husbands and in-laws can invoke this framework directly.

Machismo and its inversion

Latino *machismo* in its positive form includes protection, provision, and honor. Its abusive inversion includes dominance, sexual entitlement, emotional control, and the positioning of male authority as culturally non-negotiable. A Latino husband who abuses his wife may frame his behavior as cultural masculinity rather than pathology — and be supported in this framing by male family members.

Respeto and the family hierarchy

Respeto is not just politeness but recognition of one's position in the family hierarchy. An older generation has authority that is not questioned; a daughter-in-law must defer to her mother-in-law; a younger brother must not

contradict an older one. In abusive family systems, the hierarchy becomes the mechanism of control — the wife cannot resist the mother-in-law's directives, cannot report the brother's hostility, cannot speak about family conflict outside the family. The pastor who expects her to "just stand up for herself" does not understand the social cost of doing so.

Shame-based social architecture

Many immigrant communities, especially first-generation, maintain strong reputational economies. Family honor is a shared asset; one member's disclosure damages the entire family. This is weaponized against victims: "Don't bring shame on the family." "Don't let outsiders see our business." "Your mother would be devastated." The victim is not just considering her own wellbeing — she is weighing it against what feels like the wellbeing of many people she loves.

Religious interpretation in Latino Catholic and evangelical contexts

Marriage is often framed with extraordinary spiritual weight — as a bond "between a man, a woman, and God" that cannot be broken without spiritual consequence. Divorce is framed as violation of a sacrament or covenant regardless of what the other partner has done. Latino evangelical and Pentecostal communities sometimes hold stricter divorce positions than the Catholic Church itself (which has an extensive annulment framework for coercion and fraud).

How these dynamics show up in abuse

- **The abuser's family as co-abusers.** Mother-in-law verbally attacks the wife; father-in-law demands she defer to the husband's authority; siblings pile on when the wife resists. The abuse is enforced not by one person but by a network. Protection orders in these situations may need to name multiple respondents.
- **The "flying monkey" pattern.** The husband does not always have to be the one inflicting harm. Family members — particularly parents and siblings — carry out the enforcement, while the husband maintains the appearance of being reasonable or even conflict-averse. The husband's passivity is itself a form of participation: he benefits from the pressure his family exerts without having to exert it himself.
- **Boundary violations framed as love.** Mothers-in-law enter homes without permission, take children without asking, override household decisions, criticize parenting choices. When the wife objects, she is framed as ungrateful, cold, Americanized, rejecting the family. "Don't you love us?" becomes the response to any limit she sets.
- **Loyalty tests.** The wife is repeatedly tested on whose side she is on. Is she loyal to her husband's family, or to herself? To the cultural community, or to her own wellbeing? Choosing her own wellbeing is framed as a betrayal of everyone.
- **Language and translation used as control.** An English-speaking husband may be the sole communicator with the outside world for a wife with limited English. She cannot reach a shelter, an advocate, or a pastor without him knowing. His version of her situation is the only one outside observers hear.
- **Immigration status as coercive tool.** Threats of deportation, threats to withdraw visa sponsorship, threats to report to ICE, threats to separate her from the children through deportation. Research (Ingram et al., *Frontiers in Sociology*, 2023) documents that nearly all perpetrators who weaponize immigration status are male; a large proportion are Hispanic/Latino, but the pattern occurs across all immigrant communities.
- **Religious/spiritual abuse in culturally-specific forms.** "A good Christian wife submits." "A good Latina does not divorce." "Your family will be punished by God if you leave." "The priest/pastor says you must reconcile." The spiritual framework of the community is weaponized as enforcement.

Why leaving is uniquely difficult for immigrant victims

- Fear of deportation for themselves or their children
- Loss of the only social network, which is usually the ethnic/religious community
- Limited English proficiency and lack of familiarity with US legal systems
- Financial dependence — often exacerbated by work authorization tied to spouse's visa
- Cultural conditioning against disclosing family problems to outsiders, especially non-community authority figures
- Fear that leaving will be culturally read as betrayal, not self-protection
- Religious interpretations of marriage as indissoluble in specific ways that may differ from mainstream US Protestant framings
- Lack of culturally-competent services in their language and community
- Children who may have closer cultural identification with the abuser's family than with the victim

What pastors can do

- **Understand the family as the unit, not just the marriage.** When you counsel, ask about in-laws, about family of origin, about who has authority in the family system. The abuse picture will often only make sense at the family level.
- **Take boundary violations seriously.** When a wife describes her mother-in-law entering without permission, do not minimize it as "well, she means well." In a coercive-control family, these are not well-meaning overreaches. They are enforcement.
- **Do not assume cultural values trump safety.** Respecting someone's culture does not mean leaving them in a dangerous situation because their community expects them to stay. The faithful response is to honor both their culture and their safety, which sometimes requires challenging cultural pressure.
- **Connect with culturally-competent advocates.** Many DV organizations have Spanish-speaking advocates, Hindi-speaking advocates, etc. The National Latin@ Network for Healthy Families and Communities and Casa de Esperanza are national resources. Local shelters increasingly have cultural-match specialists.
- **Do not discuss immigration status without explicit permission.** Never disclose a congregant's immigration status to anyone, including ICE, law enforcement, or other church members. Know that immigration attorneys (RMIAN in Colorado: 303-433-2812) handle VAWA self-petitions and U-visas for DV victims, which can lead to legal status independent of the abuser.
- **Understand your own theological position might be more restrictive than the broader church.** If your congregation is Latino evangelical, you may be holding a stricter divorce position than the Catholic tradition you are distinguishing from, and stricter than the mainstream Protestant evangelical position. Part 4 of this document addresses this.

PART 4

What scripture actually says

Pastors counseling victims of coercive control are often in a difficult theological position: they want to honor scripture, they take marriage seriously, and they are hearing a woman describe a situation that seems to require divorce. What does the Bible actually say?

The answer is more favorable to victims than the standard pastoral repertoire usually acknowledges. The biblical scholarship of the last several decades — including conservative evangelical scholarship — has produced substantial consensus that abuse constitutes grounds for separation and divorce. What follows is a summary of the scholarship, not a denominational position. Readers are encouraged to check the sources against their own traditions.

Malachi 2:16 — "God hates divorce"?

The verse most commonly quoted against abused wives is Malachi 2:16, usually in its traditional rendering:

> *"For I hate divorce," says the LORD God of Israel.* — *Malachi 2:16, NIV 1984*

Modern biblical scholarship has reached substantial consensus that this translation is inaccurate. The Hebrew verb *sane'* (שָׂנֵא) in Malachi 2:16 is in the third-person masculine singular — "he hates," not "I hate." For the traditional rendering to work, a translator must either emend the Hebrew text or treat a third-person verb as first-person. The Masoretic Text does not support the first-person reading.

The surrounding grammar also points away from God as the subject. The verse continues by describing someone who "covers his garment with violence." If God were the subject, God would be the one covered with violence — incoherent in context. If the subject is "a man who hates" his wife, the sentence becomes coherent: the man hates, divorces, and in doing so covers himself with violence.

For these reasons, most current translations have moved away from the traditional rendering:

- **ESV (current edition):** "For the man who does not love his wife but divorces her, says the LORD, the God of Israel, covers his garment with violence."
- **CSB (2017):** "If he hates and divorces his wife," says the LORD God of Israel, "he covers his garment with injustice."
- **NIV (2011 revision):** "The man who hates and divorces his wife," says the LORD, the God of Israel, "does violence to the one he should protect."

The ESV's own footnote acknowledges: *"Hebrew who hates and divorces."* Barbara Roberts, in *Not Under Bondage* (2008), documents eighteen scholarly translations that render this verse with "he hates" rather than "I hate." C. Jack Collins (Covenant Seminary) confirms the grammatical reading. The "I hate divorce" rendering was popularized by the 1611 KJV and passed down since.

What Malachi 2:16 actually condemns

Read plainly in the Hebrew, Malachi 2:16 describes and condemns a specific pattern: **a man who hates his wife, sends her away, and in doing so commits violence against her.** The subject of condemnation is the abusive husband — not the wife who leaves him. Translated accurately, the verse is on the victim's side, not against her.

Jesus, the Pharisees, and "any cause" divorce

Matthew 5, Matthew 19, and Mark 10 record Jesus addressing divorce. These passages are often applied as blanket prohibitions. In the first-century context, Jesus was answering a specific rabbinic controversy, not addressing the full question of when divorce is permitted.

Two rabbinic schools held competing positions on Deuteronomy 24:1, which permitted divorce for "some indecency":

- **The school of Shammai** read the text narrowly: "some indecency" meant sexual immorality only. Divorce was permitted only for adultery.
- **The school of Hillel** read the text expansively: "some indecency" meant anything displeasing to the husband. A man could divorce his wife for burning dinner. This had become dominant Jewish practice — essentially no-fault divorce at male discretion.

When the Pharisees in Matthew 19:3 asked Jesus "Is it lawful to divorce one's wife *for any cause*?" they were using the technical term for the Hillelite position. "For any cause" is the shorthand for Hillel. They were asking Jesus to weigh in on the Hillel-Shammai dispute.

Jesus's answer — that marriage is one flesh, that Deuteronomy 24 was a concession to hardness of heart, and that the only ground he named was sexual immorality — was a rejection of "any cause" divorce. He was closing off divorce as a tool of male convenience. He was not addressing other legitimate biblical grounds such as those in Exodus 21.

Exodus 21 and the three marriage obligations

Exodus 21:10-11 is the foundational Old Testament law on marriage obligations:

> *"If he takes another wife to himself, he shall not diminish her food, her clothing, or her marital rights. And if he does not do these three things for her, she shall go out for nothing, without payment of money."* — *Exodus 21:10-11, ESV*

First-century rabbinic tradition, documented in the Mishnah (tractate Ketubot), universally extended this to all wives: if a slave-wife was entitled to food, clothing, and marital love, a free wife was entitled to at least that much. Both Hillelites and Shammaites agreed that a husband who failed to provide these three things had broken the marriage, and the wife had grounds to leave. This was settled, uncontested rabbinic law. The Hebrew term *onah* (translated "marital rights") was understood to include emotional faithfulness, not merely physical presence.

David Instone-Brewer (Senior Research Fellow in Rabbinics and New Testament at Tyndale House, Cambridge) documented in *Divorce and Remarriage in the Bible* (2002) that Jesus's audience would have understood this background. Jesus did not address Exodus 21 because no one in his audience disputed it. His silence on Exodus 21 cannot be read as rejection of it.

Paul's teaching in 1 Corinthians 7, where husbands and wives "owe" each other "conjugal rights" and are not to "deprive" one another, is written in direct continuity with the Exodus 21 framework. Paul was reminding the Corinthian church of the baseline obligations of marriage — and by implication, what it means to break them.

By this framework, sustained emotional, psychological, or spiritual abuse constitutes abandonment of the marriage covenant. A husband who does not provide for his wife's emotional and relational wellbeing (*onah*) has failed the baseline biblical standard. This is not a novel reading. It is the straightforward application of what first-century Jews understood marriage to be.

1 Corinthians 7:15 and constructive desertion

Paul's other direct teaching on divorce is 1 Corinthians 7:15:

> *"But if the unbeliever leaves, let it be so. The brother or the sister is not bound in such circumstances; God has called us to live in peace."* — *1 Corinthians 7:15, NIV*

The standard Protestant reading, held across Reformed, Lutheran, Anglican, and mainstream evangelical traditions, is that abandonment constitutes biblical grounds for divorce.

The Puritan theologians extended this through the concept of **constructive desertion** — a spouse who so fundamentally breaks the marriage covenant that they have effectively abandoned it, even without physically leaving. The Westminster Confession of Faith (1646), Chapter 24, Section 6, explicitly identifies "willful, obstinate, and malicious desertion" as grounds for divorce. John Calvin in his commentary on 1 Corinthians 7 affirmed that a spouse who refuses the obligations of marriage has abandoned it in substance.

A spouse engaged in sustained coercive control or spiritual manipulation has abandoned the marriage covenant in everything but physical presence. This fits the Puritan category of constructive desertion with precision. It is not a modern innovation — it is a four-century-old Protestant theological category that applies directly to abuse.

Paul's closing phrase — "God has called us to live in peace" — is often overlooked but theologically significant. It is Paul's stated reason for permitting the believer to release the departing spouse. The gospel does not require bondage to a covenant that has been broken beyond peace.

The broader biblical witness

Beyond the specific divorce texts, scripture's consistent testimony about God's relationship to the oppressed is directly relevant. Representative passages:

- **Exodus 22:22-24:** explicit protection of widows and orphans; God hears the cry of the oppressed.
- **Psalm 10:17-18:** "You hear the desire of the afflicted... to do justice to the fatherless and the oppressed."
- **Psalm 34:18:** "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted and saves the crushed in spirit."
- **Isaiah 1:17:** "Learn to do good; seek justice, correct oppression."
- **Isaiah 61:1-3 / Luke 4:18-19:** Jesus identifies his ministry with liberation of the captives.
- **Matthew 25:40:** what is done to "the least of these" is done to Christ.

Diane Langberg argues in *Redeeming Power* (2020) that theological frameworks which require abuse victims to remain in dangerous marriages for institutional preservation represent a misreading of the whole biblical witness. Such frameworks protect the oppressor, which is the opposite of the consistent scriptural pattern of divine concern for the oppressed.

Denominational positions in 2026

The impression that mainstream Christianity opposes divorce for abuse is inaccurate. The current positions of major evangelical denominations:

- **Southern Baptist Convention:** 2018 Resolution on Abuse states that biblical headship "does not require [wives and children] to submit to sin or to abuse." Russell Moore, former SBC ERLC president and current *Christianity Today* editor, has written that divorce for abuse is permitted and often necessary.
- **Presbyterian Church in America:** holds to the Westminster Confession, which identifies willful desertion as grounds for divorce. The 2022 PCA Ad-Interim Committee Report on Domestic Abuse explicitly affirms that patterns of abuse qualify as constructive desertion.
- **Evangelical Free Church, Christian and Missionary Alliance, Assemblies of God, Evangelical Presbyterian Church:** all have position papers affirming abuse as biblical grounds for separation and, in most framings, divorce.

- **Association of Vineyard Churches:** pastoral approach emphasizes safety and victim support without requiring victims to remain in unsafe marriages.
- **Roman Catholic Church:** though doctrinally opposed to divorce, maintains an extensive annulment framework that recognizes marriages contracted or maintained under coercion, fraud, or grave psychological incapacity. Catholic canon law provides substantial provision for abuse victims.

The pastoral-theological implication

A pastor who tells an abuse victim "God hates divorce, you must stay" is not representing the mainstream of Christian teaching. That is a minority position held most often in congregations that also have poor abuse responses generally. It is not the position of the SBC, PCA, Vineyard, the Reformed tradition, the Wesleyan tradition, or the broader evangelical scholarly consensus.

The pastoral question is not whether scripture permits divorce for abuse — the mainstream of the church has long answered yes. The pastoral question is whether your response will help her get out safely, or add a theological obstacle to her doing so.

Responding when someone quotes scripture at a victim

Abusers and their allies often quote scripture — sometimes sincerely, often tactically — to pressure victims to stay. Pastors and lay helpers need ready responses. A brief scripting guide for common verses:

"God hates divorce" (Malachi 2:16)

Reply: "That's the traditional rendering, but modern translations including the ESV, CSB, and NIV have moved away from it because the Hebrew verb is third-person — 'he hates.' Read the verse in the current ESV. It's actually condemning the man who hates and divorces his wife, which is the abuser, not the wife who leaves."

"Wives submit to your husbands" (Ephesians 5:22)

Reply: "Read the next three verses. Husbands are told to love their wives as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her. When a husband has stopped loving sacrificially, the submission being asked for is to someone not occupying the biblical role of husband. The SBC's 2018 Resolution on Abuse explicitly states that headship does not require submission to sin or abuse."

"What God has joined, let no man separate" (Matthew 19:6)

Reply: "Jesus said that in response to Pharisees asking about 'any cause' divorce — men divorcing wives for trivial reasons. He wasn't addressing abuse, abandonment, or covenant-breaking. Paul explicitly permits separation in 1 Corinthians 7:15 when a spouse is no longer engaging in the marriage in good faith."

"You need to forgive and reconcile"

Reply: "Forgiveness is between the victim and God, on her timeline, and does not require reconciliation. Reconciliation requires demonstrated, sustained repentance over time, verified by professionals — not just the abuser saying sorry. Biblical forgiveness does not require returning to the situation that caused the harm."

"Turn the other cheek" / "bear your cross"

Reply: "Jesus was teaching about personal injuries and persecution for the gospel. He was not teaching wives to tolerate abuse from their husbands. Scripture consistently shows God defending the oppressed against their oppressors — the pattern of abuse is exactly the pattern God calls his people to resist, not to accept."

PART 5

Common pastoral mistakes

These are the most common well-intentioned errors pastors make. Each has been documented in the literature, each has been named by survivors as harmful, and each can usually be replaced with a better response.

Mistake 1: Recommending couples counseling when abuse is present

Couples counseling assumes both partners share responsibility for the problem and can speak freely. In abusive relationships, neither is true. Disclosures made in session are punished later. The abuser learns the victim's vulnerabilities and uses therapeutic language to manipulate more effectively. Every major authority on DV treatment — Lundy Bancroft, Diane Langberg, Leslie Vernick, the MEND Project, the Biblical Counseling Coalition — has stated explicitly that couples counseling is contraindicated in abuse.

Instead: Separate individual counseling. The victim needs a DV-informed counselor. The abuser needs a batterer intervention program (BIP), which is different from anger management — anger management does not work for coercive control and may make it worse.

Mistake 2: Pushing premature reconciliation and forgiveness

Rushing a victim to "forgive and move forward" or to "give the marriage another chance" before the abuser has done sustained work. Abuse reliably increases when reunification occurs too quickly. The abuser learns that their behavior can be tolerated if they perform contrition convincingly.

Instead: Forgiveness is between the victim and God, on her timeline. It does not require reconciliation. Reconciliation requires verified, sustained change over years, not weeks — verified by professionals and by the victim's own safety assessment, not by the abuser's self-report.

Mistake 3: Misapplying submission theology

Telling a victim she needs to "submit more," be a "better wife," pray harder, or that "God hates divorce." This gives theological cover to abuse and weaponizes the church's authority against the victim.

Instead: Quote the SBC Resolution on Abuse: "Biblical headship blesses, honors, and protects wives and children and does not require them to submit to sin or abuse." If your tradition does not hold this explicitly, note that no mainstream evangelical denomination requires submission to abuse.

Mistake 4: Blaming the victim or asking what she did to provoke it

Asking the victim to examine her own behavior, confess her sins to the abuser, or consider what she might have contributed. This is not pastoral humility. It is victim-blaming, and it gives the abuser new material to use.

Instead: Name the abuse as wrong, unequivocally. The victim's imperfections do not cause or justify abuse. No one "made" the abuser abusive; he chose it.

Mistake 5: Breaking confidentiality to the abuser

Telling the abuser what the victim disclosed, or confronting the abuser based on her information. This is extremely dangerous. Post-disclosure is the highest-risk period for physical violence.

Instead: Never disclose to the abuser what the victim has shared. Do not attempt to confront, counsel, or convert the abuser based on the victim's information. This is not pastoral cowardice; it is basic safety.

Mistake 6: Believing the abuser's repentance at face value

Abusers are often charming, articulate, and convincing. They may cry, quote scripture, and appear genuinely broken. They may even seek pastoral care for their abuse and perform insight.

Instead: Require long-term accountability through a batterer intervention program (not anger management). Verification comes from professionals over years, not from the abuser's self-report over weeks. See the voluntary-abuser-programs research for what actual change looks like — sustained, identity-level, behavior-specific.

Mistake 7: Failing to involve professionals

Pastors are not trained DV counselors and should not try to manage these situations alone. Doing so puts the victim at risk and puts the pastor outside their competence.

Instead: Refer to DV professionals, hotlines, and legal advocates. Partner with local DV organizations before you need them. Keep the numbers posted somewhere visible in the church office.

Mistake 8: Treating the family of origin as peripheral

In immigrant and collectivist-culture contexts, the abuser's family is often part of the abuse structure, not a separate issue. Treating the marriage as a two-person problem when it is actually a family-system problem misses the dynamics.

Instead: Ask about in-laws, extended family, and family-of-origin authority structures. Recognize that boundary violations by the spouse's family are often part of the coercive control pattern, not independent of it. Colorado protection orders can name multiple respondents.

Mistake 9: Asking the victim to stay for the children

The assumption that children are better off with both parents regardless of what is happening between them. The research is unambiguous: children in coercive-control households are harmed by exposure to the pattern even when the abuse is not directed at them. Leaving is usually protective for the children, not harmful to them.

Instead: Help the victim see that leaving is often the strongest parenting choice she can make. Children whose non-abusive parent removes them from a coercive environment show better outcomes across virtually every measured domain than children who remain exposed.

Mistake 10: Treating neurodivergence or culture as explaining the dysfunction

"She's autistic, so of course he has to manage things." "They're a traditional Latino family, that's just how it works." Accepting the abuser's or the family's framing of why the dynamic is normal or necessary.

Instead: Autism does not require a controlling spouse. Traditional culture does not require abuse. These framings are excuses for abuse, not explanations of it. A pastor who accepts the framing becomes part of the enforcement system.

PART 6

Practical protocols

When someone discloses abuse

- **Believe them.** It takes extraordinary courage to disclose. Victims minimize rather than exaggerate. Your first response is the most important thing you will do in this relationship — it sets the frame for everything after.
- **Say it explicitly: "This is not your fault."** Do not assume she knows this. Most don't.
- **Do not confront the abuser.** This puts her in danger. Post-disclosure is the highest-risk window.
- **Assess immediate safety.** "Are you safe right now? Are your children safe? Is there a safe place you can go tonight if needed?"
- **Connect to professionals immediately.** National DV Hotline: 1-800-799-7233. Text START to 88788. Local DV advocates if you have a relationship. Do this in the session with her, not "later."
- **Do not require her to stay.** Do not quote "God hates divorce." Do not suggest couples counseling. Do not require confession or reconciliation.
- **Document what she shares (with her permission).** Date-stamped notes kept securely, not visible to staff. She may need this for legal proceedings later.
- **Know your mandatory reporting obligations.** If children are involved, you may be a mandatory reporter in your state. In Colorado, clergy are mandatory reporters of child abuse. Know the law.

Screening questions (individual session, never joint)

- "Are you ever afraid of your partner?"
- "Does your partner control the money, the schedule, or who you see?"
- "Has your partner ever threatened you or the children?"
- "Do you feel like you have to manage your own behavior carefully to avoid your partner's anger?"
- "Has your partner ever prevented you from leaving the house, seeing friends, or going to church?"
- "Has your partner ever destroyed things, harmed a pet, or damaged property?"
- "Does your partner check your phone, email, social media, or location?"
- "Does your partner's family treat you in ways that make you uncomfortable, and does your partner back them up?"
- "Has anyone in the family threatened to contact immigration, or threatened your status in any way?"

Safety planning basics

If she is ready to talk about leaving, help her think through:

- A safe place she can go — friend, family, shelter
- Documents she will want to have (ID, SSN cards, birth certificates, financial records, immigration documents)
- A phone he doesn't monitor (prepaid phone from Walmart, or a borrowed one)
- A code word with a trusted friend that means "call 911"
- A plan for the children — school, pickup authorization, who to contact
- A plan for pets

- Enrollment in the Colorado Address Confidentiality Program (ACP: 303-866-2208, dcs.colorado.gov/acp) — a free statewide program that provides a legal substitute address

Immediate resources to have memorized or posted

- **National DV Hotline:** 1-800-799-7233 (24/7, multilingual). Text START to 88788.
- **National Sexual Assault Hotline (RAINN):** 1-800-656-4673
- **National Latin@ Network / Casa de Esperanza:** 1-651-646-5553 (culturally-competent DV support)
- **Strong Hearts Native Helpline:** 1-844-762-8483 (for Native/Indigenous victims)
- **Your local DV shelter:** KNOW THIS NUMBER. Build the relationship before you need it.

When to refer out entirely

There are situations where a pastor's best response is to refer quickly and stay in a supportive role only, not a counseling role. These include:

- Any case involving ongoing physical violence or weapon access
- Any case involving substance abuse on the abuser's part
- Any case where the victim is in active suicidal crisis
- Any case involving child sexual abuse (mandatory reporting applies)
- Any case where the victim's primary language is not one you can counsel in fluently
- Any case involving immigration status
- Any case involving complex legal or custody issues you are not trained in

Referring out is not abandoning her. It is acknowledging that she deserves actual expertise, and that trying to provide it yourself when you don't have it is worse than helping her connect with people who do. Your role after referral is pastoral support and practical help, not counseling.

PART 7

Resources and further reading

Essential reading (in recommended order)

Start with these three, in this order:

- **Lundy Bancroft,** *Why Does He Do That? Inside the Minds of Angry and Controlling Men* (2002). The definitive text on abuser psychology. Essential foundation for understanding what coercive control is and what it isn't.
- **Leslie Vernick,** *The Emotionally Destructive Marriage* (2013). Christian licensed counselor. Distinguishes destructive from difficult marriages. The clearest pastoral-facing treatment of the topic.
- **Diane Langberg,** *Redeeming Power: Understanding Authority and Abuse in the Church* (2020). How power is used and abused in church settings. Pastoral-theological framework for recognizing and addressing the pattern.

Also valuable:

- **Steven R. Tracy,** *Mending the Soul: Understanding and Healing Abuse* (2nd ed., 2022). Theologically grounded, psychologically informed.
- **Justin S. Holcomb & Lindsey A. Holcomb,** *Is It My Fault? Hope and Healing for Those Suffering Domestic Violence* (2014). Gospel-centered resource for survivors; pastors should read it to understand what survivors are encountering.
- **Jeff Crippen & Anna Wood,** *A Cry for Justice: How the Evil of Domestic Abuse Hides in Your Church* (2012). Written by a pastor. How abusers operate in church communities.
- **Barbara Roberts,** *Not Under Bondage: Biblical Divorce for Abuse, Adultery and Desertion* (2008). Scholarly treatment of the biblical case. Contains the eighteen-translation appendix on Malachi 2:16.
- **David Instone-Brewer,** *Divorce and Remarriage in the Bible* (Eerdmans, 2002). Rigorous historical scholarship on first-century Jewish marriage law and New Testament interpretation.
- **Chuck DeGroat,** *When Narcissism Comes to Church* (2020). Narcissism in ministry leaders and church systems.
- **Wade Mullen,** *Something's Not Right* (2020). How abusive institutions (including churches) manage image to protect themselves.

Free training programs

- **Becoming a Church that Cares Well for the Abused** (Brad Hambrick, churchcares.com). FREE 12-lesson video curriculum. Contributors include Rachael Denhollander, Diane Langberg, Leslie Vernick. Adopted by all six SBC seminaries. This is the single best starting point.
- **FaithTrust Institute** (faithtrustinstitute.org). Multifaith clergy training. Free recorded webinars.

Training programs (paid or organization-based)

- **Called to Peace Ministries** (calledtopeace.org). Survivor-founded. Training for pastors and ministry leaders.
- **Mending the Soul Ministries** (mendingthesoul.org). Evangelical abuse prevention and education.
- **The MEND Project** (themendproject.com). Responder training, coercive control education, specializes in when couples counseling is appropriate vs. harmful.

- **Give Her Wings Academy** (giveherwings.com/curriculum). Church leader training for ministering to abuse survivors.
- **GRACE** (netgrace.org). Independent investigations, training, education for Christian organizations on abuse prevention and response.

Resources specific to neurodivergence

- NeuroClastic: neuroclastic.com — autistic-led writing on autism and abuse dynamics
- ADHD Works (adhdworks.info) — ADHD-specific vulnerability and coercion patterns
- Douglas & Sedgewick (2024), "Experiences of Interpersonal Victimization and Abuse Among Autistic People," *Autism*
- Cazalis et al. (2022), "Nine Autistic Women Out of Ten Have Been Victims of Sexual Violence," *Frontiers in Behavioral Neuroscience*
- Psychology Today: "Gaslighting and Neurodiversity" (Feb 2024)

Resources specific to immigrant and Latino communities

- **National Latin@ Network for Healthy Families and Communities:** nationallatinonetwork.org
- **Casa de Esperanza:** casadeesperanza.org, 1-651-646-5553
- **National Immigrant Women's Advocacy Project** (NIWAP, American University): niwaplibrary.wcl.american.edu
- **Rocky Mountain Immigrant Advocacy Network (Colorado):** 303-433-2812, rmian.org — detention, VAWA self-petitions, U-visas

Denominational position papers

- **Southern Baptist Convention, On Abuse** (2018): sbc.net/resource-library/resolutions/on-abuse/
- **PCA Ad-Interim Committee Report on Domestic Abuse** (2022): pcaac.org
- **USCCB, When I Call for Help: A Pastoral Response to Domestic Violence Against Women**
- **CBE International:** extensive library on DV, clergy response, and complementarian theology's interaction with coercive control: cbeinternational.org

Survivor voices worth reading

- Rachael Denhollander — attorney and abuse survivor, prolific writer on church response
- Jenn Greenberg — survivor and author, jenngreenberg.org
- A Cry for Justice (blog): cryingoutforjustice.blog
- Life-Saving Divorce: lifesavingdivorce.com

Quick-start recommendations for a pastor with 10 hours

- Watch all 12 free lessons at churchcares.com (~6 hours)
- Read Bancroft's *Why Does He Do That?* (~4 hours)
- Call your local DV shelter and ask for a 30-minute intro conversation
- Post the National DV Hotline number somewhere visible in the church office
- Train 2-3 lay leaders to receive disclosures and connect survivors to resources

APPENDIX

Printable quick-reference card

Print this card double-sided, fold in half, and keep it in a Bible or desk drawer.

When Someone Discloses Abuse

DO

✓ Believe her. She is minimizing, not exaggerating.
✓ Say out loud: "This is not your fault."
✓ Ask: "Are you safe right now? Are the children?"
✓ Call National DV Hotline in-session: 1-800-799-7233
✓ Keep her disclosures STRICTLY confidential from the abuser.
✓ Document (with her permission) with date and time.

DO NOT

✗ Confront the abuser. Do not tell him what she said.
✗ Recommend couples counseling. It makes abuse worse.
✗ Quote "God hates divorce." (The Hebrew actually says he hates.)
✗ Tell her to forgive quickly, submit more, or pray harder.
✗ Attribute her distress to autism, ADHD, culture, or hormones.
✗ Assume the calm, charming partner is the reasonable one.
✗ Handle this alone. Refer to professionals.

Key Questions & Numbers

DIAGNOSTIC QUESTIONS (INDIVIDUAL, NOT JOINT)

- Are you ever afraid of your partner?
- Does your partner control money, schedule, or who you see?
- Has your partner threatened you or the children?
- Do you manage your own behavior to avoid his anger?
- Does his family treat you in ways he supports or ignores?
- Has anyone threatened immigration or legal status?

CRITICAL NUMBERS

National DV Hotline: 1-800-799-7233
Text START to 88788
RAINN (sexual violence): 1-800-656-4673
Casa de Esperanza (Latina): 1-651-646-5553
Strong Hearts (Native): 1-844-762-8483
Colorado Address Confidentiality Program: 303-866-2208
RMIAN (immigration + DV, Colorado): 303-433-2812
Local shelter: _____
Local DV-informed attorney: _____

IF SHE IS IN IMMEDIATE DANGER: CALL 911

Compiled April 2026. Scriptural analysis draws on Roberts, Not Under Bondage (2008); Instone-Brewer, Divorce and Remarriage in the Bible (Eerdmans, 2002); Moore (2022); Langberg (2020); Vernick (2013); Crippen & Wood (2012); Holcomb & Holcomb (2014); the scholarly tradition on Malachi 2:16 (Collins, Shields, Pope, Mowczko); Westminster Confession of Faith (1646). Denominational positions: SBC 2018 Resolution on Abuse; PCA 2022 Ad-Interim Committee Report on Domestic Abuse. Neurodivergence research: Douglas & Sedgewick (2024); Cazalis et al. (2022); CHADD; NeuroClastic. Immigrant/Latino research: Ingram et al., "Use of Immigration Status for Coercive Control in Domestic Violence Protection Orders," Frontiers in Sociology (2023); Castillo et al., Marianismo Beliefs Scale (2010); Nuñez et al. (2015); National Latin@ Network. Colorado-specific resources (CLS Greeley 970-353-7554, RMIAN 303-433-2812, ACP 303-866-2208) verified current as of April 20, 2026.